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T he Bronze Age—Mycenaean Society



I ntroduction

By the sixteenth century BC, Mycenae was the most important of the Achaean states. Wealth came from overseas trade and warrior raids. Kings lived within massively walled fortresses. Our knowledge of the royal lifestyles and events are from archaeological findings. The Mycenaeans dominated trade in the eastern Mediterranean until the twelfth century BC when Mycenaean power was destroyed.

O utcomes

On completing this chapter students should be able to:

- describe and assess the significance of key people, groups, events, institutions, societies and sites within their historical context
- explain historical factors and assess their significance in contributing to change and continuity in the ancient world
- locate, select and organise relevant information from a variety of sources
- discuss relevant problems of sources for reconstructing the past
- analyse and evaluate sources for their usefulness and reliability
- explain and evaluate differing perspectives and interpretations of the past
- plan and present the findings of historical investigations, analysing and synthesising information from a range of sources
- use historical terms and concepts appropriately
- communicate a knowledge and understanding of historical features and issues using appropriate oral and written forms.

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Key terms and concepts

Achaean

trade

Linear B script

Indo-Europeans

Helladic

civilisation

Trojan War

epic poems

tholoi

megaron

merchant

pithoi

grave circles

shaft-graves

rhyton

dromos

temenos

wanax

hepetai

cult

gods/goddesses

Dorians

city-states

GEOGRAPHY, SETTING AND RESOURCES

8.1 HISTORICAL CONTEXT

- The first Indo-European settlers arrived in Greece in the nineteenth century BC. 'Infiltration' is probably more accurate than 'invasion', but historians still dispute this.
- These early Greek-speaking people were known by later Greeks as the **Achaean**s. Their civilisation has become known as **Mycenaean**, and the people, **Mycenaeans**. Their most powerful town was Mycenae.
- The early history of Greece is conventionally divided into three periods: Early, Middle, and Late **Helladic** (Greek Bronze Age). It is only the **third period** (c.1600BC to 1100BC) that concerns us here and specifically the peak period of the thirteenth century BC.

 *The **Mycenaean Age** was the age of the legendary heroes and of the development of Mycenaean civilisation.*

- The influence of the Minoans after c.1600BC was widespread until Knossos (on Crete) was destroyed. Mycenaean culture was a blend of Minoan and mainland traditions.
- The Mycenaean were a different race to the Minoans. The kings were taller than the Minoans, they wore beards and the wealthy rode in chariots. Standing stones over early Mycenaean shaft-graves were carved with war scenes not atypical of the depictions of Minoan culture.

Geography and resources

- **Mycenae** was located in the region of the Peloponnese on the Greek mainland. This area

was the most fertile plain in Greece during the Bronze Age period.

- **Crops and livestock** included barley, wheat, figs, olives, grapes, sheep, goats and pigs.
- The surrounding mountains provided essential **raw materials** of stone and timber in addition to natural fortifications.
- Mycenae was **strategically located** in a central position. It was the connecting point between the northern and southern plains of Argive and Corinth.

8.2 SIGNIFICANT SITES

- The civilisation of the Mycenaean survived for more than four centuries. It faded in the period 1200BC to 1100BC. Our knowledge of these people, as with the Minoans, is almost exclusively due to archaeological findings. This immediately limits what can be known about Mycenaean.
- Sparta and Pylos were other Mycenaean centres in the Peloponnese.

SOCIAL STRUCTURE AND POLITICAL ORGANISATION

8.3 THE RULER AND RULING CLASS

- Minoan society and culture were brought into the mainland palace-states. Bureaucratic administration was adopted from the Minoans; the palaces were the control centres of society.
- The **Linear B** tablets from Knossos and Pylos throw light on the system of administration revealing numerous and meticulous records covering agriculture, storage, land-holdings, and religious involvement:

- i. **Palace administration:** wealth and treasure were centred, as they were on Crete, in the king's palace. The king had his own **temenos** or land-reservation and this was farmed for his direct use. The palace controlled most aspects of everyday life.
 - ii. **King's nobles:** small towns and villages were scattered over the countryside, dominated by the king's nobles and officials.
 - iii. **The king:** society was headed by the king (**wanax**). His court was made up of nobles and companions. His duties were administrative and religious, and he could have been considered divine.
 - iv. **The war leader:** the war leader (**lawagetas**) could have vied for the kingship. He is generally described as the leader of the people.
 - v. **King's advisers:** the king had his **hequetai** or advisers; people always close to the king. **Hequetai** may have had important military duties. There were also governors of subordinate towns.
 - vi. **The nobility:** the nobility (**basileis**) were below the king and served him in time of war. They also gave to the king part of their produce.
 - vii. **The telestai:** were groups of individuals in significant standing in the community and acquired status through landholdings. They acted as the royal bureaucracy.
- Unfortunately, the **Linear B** tablets do not tell of any political transactions or sequenced events. Writing was mainly used for keeping accounts, and for everyday administration.
 - The ruling class gave service in war, control of government, and produce-payment for land.
 - Military organisation was regarded as complex. Forces were stationed in parts of the south-west Peloponnese, near the coast, and probably elsewhere.

8.4 THE LOWER CLASSES

- **Agricultural workers** leased the land of landholders and were known as **damos**. They inhabited many of the surrounding valleys and were the main source of labour for agricultural and manufacturing work.

- **Artisans** were specialist workers responsible for the production of pottery and frescoes, which were integral features of Mycenaean palaces.
- **Slaves**, also known as **lawiaia** (captives), were predominantly women who were taken prisoner, transported back to Mycenae and mobilised into areas such as the cloth industry, corn grinding and domestic duties.

8.5 ROLE AND STATUS OF WOMEN

- The characters of Penelope and Nausicaa in **Homer's works** reinforce the image of the idealised woman, which can be dated back to the Mycenaean period.
- Homer suggests that **aristocratic women** held some element of independence such as moving freely without escorts and discussing issues with their husbands on equal terms.
- Regardless of class, women both royal and slave engaged in similar tasks. Royal women however could make their own choice as to whether or not to involve themselves in such work.
- Such activities included managing households, domestic chores, clothing production, spinning and weaving.
- **Domestic chores** included collecting water, furnishing baths and grinding corn.

THE ECONOMY

8.6 AGRICULTURE AND INDUSTRY

- Mycenaeans were self-supporting from corn crops, stock-raising, and hunting, but raw materials had to be imported.
- The Mycenaeans proved to be successful traders. They imported metals, including tin and copper. From about 1400BC, the Mycenaeans replaced the Minoan traders in Egypt, Syria, Palestine and Cyprus.

Mycenaean trade partner	Imports by Mycenaeans
Egypt	Gold, exotic stones, luxuries, papyrus, flint
Syria	Textiles, ivory
Cyprus	Copper, bronze

- Pottery workshops were numerous and potters were kept very busy supplying domestic needs

and storage jars for the palaces and merchants' houses.

- Metal workers produced a wide range of products, weapons, armour and tools, as documented in tomb discoveries at Mycenae and Tiryns.
- There were also ivory carvers, jewellers, and gem carvers, who reached a high level of artistry and craft.

8.7 THE SIGNIFICANCE OF PALACES

- The fortifications and weapons recovered indicate war-like and disturbed conditions, unlike those on Crete. Ruling families occupied the fortified citadels which supplied the needs of everyday life through a system of mutual dependence. They also functioned as redistribution points for certain commodities, such as bronze ingots at Pylos, which were redistributed to specialised groups of workers.
- Mycenaean citadels (or fortresses) were built well inland. Guard towers on the hills were for control of movements on the secondary roads. Mycenae became predominant and (according to Homer) controlled the area known as the Argolid, and would have included the towns of Corinth and Tiryns (which had its own massive defences).
- The palace functioned as the main channel of economic distribution. Wealth was created through trade and levies. Mycenae was at the centre of the Mediterranean trade-route.
- Central Greece also established significant towns with citadels, such as at Athens and Thebes.

8.8 TRADE AND ECONOMIC EXCHANGE

- Trade and expansion usually went together. From Mycenae, traders went to southern Italy and the Aegean. The main line of expansion, including raids and colonisation, followed the Cretan expansion, taking in the islands and, perhaps, the coast of Asia Minor.
- Useful items such as olive oil, pottery, and animal hides were exchanged for luxury goods such as spices, ivory, and jewellery.

- Trade with Syria was very profitable. An ivory-carving industry was inspired by the Syrian ivory trade. Some Greek merchants and artisans settled in the town of Ugarit; Tarsus in Asia Minor became a colony.
- Other colonies were founded as trading and bases for piracy.
- Rhodes and Cyprus contained important colonies; Miletus, on the west coast of Asia Minor, was also colonised.
- According to legend, the expedition against Troy was one of the last overseas adventures of the Mycenaeans. It took 10 years to complete the siege of Troy. Finally it was taken through trickery.

8.9 TECHNOLOGICAL DEVELOPMENTS

- The Mycenaean's used the sword, spear and bow in **combat**. During their period of expansion they incorporated the chariot, full body bronze armour and the figure of eight and tower shields made from leather or ox hide.
- The Mycenaean's **quarried stone** from the surrounding mountains, which provided the majority of raw materials required for building and construction.
- They adopted new techniques of construction with the use of **ashlar masonry**. This involved the use of small, square and thin pieces of stone.
- Mycenaean architecture witnessed the introduction of **corbelling** which involved projecting a piece of stone or timber, coming out from a wall and taking the weight, acting like a parapet.

RELIGION, DEATH AND BURIAL

8.10 BELIEFS, PRACTICES AND ORGANISATION

- Pictorial evidence suggests that Mycenaean religious practice was of formalised worship and ritual. Deities had specialised functions and status and appear on seals, rings, and grave artefacts.
- There were, in religion, as in other areas, strong ties with Minoan practices. However, there were some unique Mycenaean customs (see below).

- There is evidence of cult participation, open-air dance and religious worship as depicted on gemstones. The **megaron** and hearth may have been involved in cult practices and were very important in later Greek religious practices.
- The **megaron** and hearth were distinctly Mycenaean. The **megaron** is the main room of the palace complex; the hearth is located in its centre.
- The use of the horns of consecration is also common. The double-headed axe appears occasionally.
- Goddesses seem to be important, however, the bull and the **labrys** (double-headed axe) are not prominent in Mycenae. Much worship was directed towards goddesses. **Potnia** was probably the universal Mother-goddess as well as a fertility figure.
- In Mycenae gods are more prominent than goddesses. Some bearded gods were also worshipped. Later, Mycenaean religion developed an Olympian polytheism (many gods), with Zeus, the patriarch. Cult idols were, however, absent in Minoan artefacts. The preference in both areas was distinctly for goddesses.
- Special rooms for worship were not usual in Mycenaean palaces, as they were in Crete. Large temples were rare, but special areas with adjacent store-rooms were found at some places. Excavations in the Citadel House or House of Idols revealed specialised areas for religious practices.
- Terracotta statues for offerings found in Hagia Eirene may have been priestesses or goddesses. This is an early form of temple depicting cult worship, which continued into the Classical Age.
- Mycenaean cults seem distantly removed from the gods of Olympus or the later mainstream religion. Cults were probably maintained by annual contributions. The Temple Room in the Citadel House would have functioned as a place of official cults.

8.11 FUNERARY CUSTOMS AND RITUALS

- Schliemann discovered grave-sites at Mycenae, originally placed outside the citadel, but incorporated within the later thirteenth-century

BC walls. The graves were formed in a circle.

- At Mycenae, the early royal tombs were deep rectangular pits (the **shaft-graves**), found in two circular areas, delineated by stone slabs. These are called **Grave Circles A and B** and contained many precious materials. Grave Circle A (c.1600BC to 1500BC) contained six shaft-graves and revealed the influx of Minoan luxuries and gold from trade, and were kings' and queens' graves.
- There were also many weapons in the graves, including richly inlaid daggers, knives, spears, swords, and a silver **rhyton** (drinking vessel) with a siege scene engraved.
- The graves in Circle A were covered with timber and clay, marked by a stone slab. A shaft was used for many burials.
- The treasures buried in Grave Circle A included, in one grave, crowns, headbands, cups, rings all made of gold, and diadems. The construction of these graves was distinctly Mycenaean although their contents indicate Minoan trade influences.
- In other graves there were highly crafted weapons. One famous sword depicts warriors on a lion-hunt. The best treasures are the work of the Minoans. Other artefacts included gold and silver vessels, pottery, and inlaid daggers. The faces of the kings were covered in gold death-masks.
- Papadimitriou and Mylonas (1952 to 1954) discovered a further 14 graves, coded **Circular B**. These were outside the walls; earlier graves indicating a very war-like society, as a number of weapons were found. There were few luxuries in Grave Circle B although they were probably royal graves.

Tholoi (tombs)

- The later burial places were plundered and robbed and burial chambers of a different type were built. The chambers, **tholoi** (tombs shaped like beehives), were cut into the side of a hill.
- These were monumental. The shape was achieved by layering narrow rings of stone upon stone. A single roof-stone covered the top and the entrance was via a passageway called a **dromos**. The **tholoi** succeeded the shaft-graves and belonged to the leading noble families.

- The best preserved **tholos** is the **Treasury of Atreus**. It is distinguished by its size, workmanship, the monumental entrance, and its interior decorations. It is 14.5 m across and 13.2 m high. The doorway is 5.4 m high and 2.7 m wide. The **tholoi** at Mycenae, built during the thirteenth century BC, include the tombs of Clytemnestra and Aegisthos.
- The ordinary people had smaller burial places which vary greatly in the wealth of their offerings, indicating status.
- From the evidence we can conclude the following about death and burial in Mycenae:
 - i. The dead were usually buried. Cremation was a later adoption of the Greeks.
 - ii. The people who built the shaft-graves were Mycenaean.
 - iii. Many offerings to the dead were burnt. The reason is unknown.
 - iv. Objects of use, as well as food and water, were given to the dead and this indicates a belief in life after death.
The dead were supposed to have need of the goods buried within the tomb.
 - vi. There is no evidence of continued offerings after the burial, except in the case of the Mycenaean kings. It is supposed that once flesh decayed, the spirit was released and had no more use of material objects.
 - vii. Subsequent burials in the same grave indicate that the remains of the long dead were disrespectfully thrown about.
 - viii. However, there is evidence of regular ritual over the graves of kings at Mycenae, indicating a belief in god-kings, above ordinary people.

CULTURAL LIFE

8.12 ARCHITECTURE

- Mycenae was built 15 km inland in a secure corner of the Argive plain. Other palaces were found at Pylos and Tiryns, Athens, and Thebes, as well as sites in Thessaly, Boeotia and Sparta.
- Pylos is the best preserved of the Mycenaean sites. It included an archival room, a store-room, bedrooms, and the throne room.

- The king's hilltop position at Mycenae provided good defence. Around the palace were quarters for the establishment, servants, soldiers, and store-rooms. Tiryns held a single palace complex. Some of the palaces were fortified with massive walls.
- The Lion Gate was the entry to the Mycenaean citadel. Two stone lions (or lionesses), symbolising the royal power, stood above the stone entrance. They were like guardians to the palace and represent a masterpiece of stone work.
- Most impressive were the extremely thick walls or fortifications, in excess of anything which would have been needed for defence. The Mycenaean were obviously different in attitude to the Minoans.
- Inside the palace the **megaron**, or great hall, was used as a meeting place with a huge hearth in the centre. This section is distinctive in Mycenaean palace architecture. The hearth formed the nucleus of such buildings.
- Within the citadel there was space for military reinforcements and safety from invaders.
- Ordinary Mycenaean lived outside the citadel but, as in a medieval castle, accommodation and safety in time of war was available inside the fortress. Also found outside the fortress at Mycenae, were merchants' houses: the House of the Oil Merchant, House of Shields, the House of the Sphinxes, and the West House.
- Refer to 8.7 for information on **fortifications and defence**.

8.13 ART

- Frescoes covered the walls of palaces, shrines, and homes, and were Minoan in technique, but Mycenaean in subject matter, such as a battle-scene at Mycenae, a boar-hunt at Tiryns, and at Pylos a battle-scene between Mycenaean and barbarians.
- **Pottery** was decorated with scenes of everyday life such as warfare and nature.
- Excavations have uncovered artefacts such as jewellery which was elaborately decorated. These features were probably due to the affluent lifestyles of the aristocracy and trade with other regions in the Aegean.

- **Jewellery** items included gold, glass, amethyst, carnelian and amber.

8.14 WRITING

- The civilisation of the Mycenaeans survived for more than four centuries. It faded in the period 1200BC to 1100BC. Our knowledge of these people, as with the Minoans, is almost exclusively due to archaeological findings. This immediately limits what can be known about Mycenaeans.
- There is no evidence of literature, laws, or documentation. It is difficult, then, to really know what the Mycenaeans were like. As with the Minoans, much of their history is surmised.
- Archaeological records and the **Linear B** tablets indicate sophisticated **economic and social organisation**.

EVERYDAY LIFE

8.15 ASPECTS OF EVERYDAY LIFE

- The evidence for **daily life** and leisure activities contained in the frescoes and on pottery reflects the social and cultural pursuits of the Mycenaean aristocracy. Most of these aspects are similar to that of the Minoans.
- **Leisure activities** included grooming horses, hunting, music, dancing and hosting banquets.
- **Clothing** was light and simple due to the climate. The aristocracy and the peasantry could be distinguished by their dress.
- **Women** wore a tight bodice, short sleeves and skirt. Dresses would often have colourful sequins with rosettes attached.
- **Men** wore loincloths or short kilts. Most of the time they would wear a simple tunic with short sleeves, a narrow waist and short skirt.
- **Occupations** included merchants, artisans, manufacturing labourers and agricultural labourers. These positions were filled by the lower classes of society.
- Adjoining the great palaces of Mycenae were houses which were small and simple in design. These were the sleeping and resting quarters of **residents**.
- Typical **furniture** included stone benches and tables, and footstools.

Revision Questions and Answers

- a Name two Mycenaean palaces. (2 marks)
- b Who was the wanax? (2 marks)
- c Describe the main features of Mycenaean royal tombs. (5 marks)
- d Describe why Mycenae was so easy to defend. (6 marks)
- e With reference to evidence you have studied, explain the importance of Mycenaean writing and what it tells us about their society. (10 marks)



- Palaces were built at Tiryns and Pylos.



- The wanax was the king of a Mycenaean city. His court consisted of nobles and companions. He performed religious and administrative duties, and was probably considered a god-king.



- Early royal tombs were rectangular pits (shaft graves) built in circular areas (grave circles). They contained precious materials, luxuries, gold from trade, and weapons, some richly inlaid with precious stones. A single shaft grave could be used for multiple burials of kings and queens. The faces of the kings were covered with gold death masks. Later tombs were the chamber tombs called tholoi. These tombs were shaped like beehives. They were monumental structures with a dromos or passageway. A single roof-stone covered the top. The best-preserved tholos is the Treasury of Atreus.



- Mycenae was easy to defend partly because of its geographic location. The great palace fortress stood at the top of a rocky acropolis commanding the Argive plain. Guards could have seen any enemy approaching from the

distance. On the other side is the Aegean Sea which was patrolled by Mycenaean ships. The city was surrounded by 6 metre thick walls and included numerous fortifications. The citadel was the strongest point and contained the king's palace. It was also probably situated on a cliff above the Aegean, so that by sea or land good warning could be given.



- Michael Ventris deciphered Linear B script found at Pylos. He determined that the language was Greek. The tablets that were found contained inventory lists, for example measures of olives, wine, chariot wheels, pigs, horses, oxen, wheat, barley, spices, tilled land, and taxes collected. This represented a window on the palace economies of Mycenae. Taxes were collected from subject states, and trade and industry (such as bronze and perfume) flourished, establishing the wealth and power of Mycenae.
- Linear B also carried the names of gods, reflecting Homer's Illiad. Also mentioned are the gifts to the gods – animal sacrifices and precious liquids, for example oxen, goats, sheep, pigs, wine and oil perfume.
- We can also determine the social hierarchy from the texts: from king and war leader, to nobles, advisers, and ordinary people.
- We learn that the society was hierarchical, well organised, specialised in industry, and well governed.

(Note: Wherever you can, refer to the particular sources you have studied for this question. A stimulus or source will also be provided with this question.)